

occasions, there was a large chunk of shares involved. My clients and my firm made a killing on those deals while AS and PS were left scratching their heads trying to figure out how they were being undercut and by whom.

I must add here that I was quite inspired by the movie *Trishul* in which Amitabh Bachchan's construction firm undercuts Sanjeev Kumar's firm's quotation by one rupee, leaving the latter fuming.

The financial loss hurt AS-PS, no doubt, but what galled them even more was the challenge to their dominance. They made some inquiries and figured out who was stealing their lunch. Naturally, they were mad enough to want to kill me. They could not confront me on this matter because the exchange did not publish the successful offers, and they did not want to explain how they found me out either.

But they let me know that they were aware of what I was up to.

'Hello Lala,' AS greeted me one day as I passed him in the ring. 'Your clients must be quite happy with you, considering the profits you have helped them earn in TISCO and Century.'

I was caught unawares, and my surprise showed. I had undercut AS on both those stocks – it had been 10 paise, as usual. AS stared at me for a few seconds and then walked off without saying anything more.

PS was less subtle when I bumped into him the following day. I tried to avoid him, but he sidled up to me and put his arm around my shoulder as if we were the best of friends. But what he had to say was anything but friendly.

'I have said this once in the past and I shall repeat it again since you seem to have trouble understanding my message. Don't mess with your fathers in the industry, Lala, you could get hurt,' he said, and moved on. As threats went, it could not get more explicit than this.

A couple of weeks later, the duo accosted me just as I was about to get into the ring for the day.

'Saale \*%#@! you think you are smart, don't you? How the \*^\$# can your firm regularly offer ten paise below our quotes?' AS asked menacingly.

'I don't know what the hell you are talking about,' I said, trying to stay calm.

AS and PS looked at each other, and AS spoke again:

'#@!\*^\$, try your acting skills somewhere else. BSE has started putting out the winning offers for the auctions on the notice board from today.'